

“All the News  
That’s Fit to Print”

# The New York Times

THE WEATHER

Today, sunny, breezy in the morning, lower humidity, not as warm, high 82. Tonight, clear, dry, low 65. Tomorrow, sunny, low humidity, high 80. Weather map is on Page B6.

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Prices in Canada may be higher

\$4.00

## Firing Powell Could Backfire For President

### If Investors Lose Faith, Rates May Spike

By BEN CASSELMAN

President Trump wants the Federal Reserve to lower interest rates. Firing Jerome H. Powell, the Fed chair, could have precisely the opposite effect, pushing up costs for home buyers, businesses and other borrowers.

Mr. Trump in recent days has intensified his long-running attacks on Mr. Powell, whom he has criticized for holding interest rates at a relatively high level even as inflation has cooled and economic growth has slowed. On Tuesday, the president asked a group of House Republicans whether he should fire Mr. Powell, and showed off a draft of a letter that would do so.

Asked on Wednesday whether he intended to fire Mr. Powell, Mr. Trump said he had no immediate plans for a removal, though he refused to rule it out. If he took such a step, it is unclear whether he would succeed. Mr. Powell has indicated his intention to serve out his term as chair, and many legal experts say the law is on his side.

Even if Mr. Trump did manage to oust Mr. Powell, the move might prove counterproductive. A new chair might be able to persuade enough other Fed officials to lower the short-term interest rates that the central bank directly controls. But the rates that matter to most borrowers are long-term rates, particularly those on 10-year and 30-year federal government bonds, which are the basis for what borrowers pay for mortgages, auto loans and

Continued on Page A17

### More on the White House

**EPSTEIN CASE** The president faces hurdles in getting grand jury testimony unsealed. PAGE A16

**POLICY SHIFT** A birth control program is focusing on helping women get pregnant. PAGE A17

## Genetic Scores Could Estimate Risk of Obesity

By GINA KOLATA

Researchers have known for decades that genetics may be more powerful than environment in predicting who will develop obesity. Identical twins tend to have the same body mass index, even if they are reared apart. Adopted children tend to have a degree of obesity similar to their birth parents rather than their adoptive ones.

Identifying the genetic roots of obesity could aid with prevention starting in childhood. But finding a genetic footprint for obesity has proved challenging. With rare exceptions, there’s not one gene or even a few that are the culprits. Instead, obesity is spurred by thousands of gene variants acting in concert. Each variant exerts a tiny effect.

Now, using genetic data from five million people, an international group of hundreds of researchers reports that it has developed an obesity risk score, known also as a polygenic risk score. It combines thousands of gene variants to estimate individuals’ predicted body mass indexes, which continue to be used by doctors to anticipate weight-related health dangers.

The researchers showed that the scores can predict which young children are at risk of obesity as adults. And, in another test, they found that overweight and

Continued on Page A20

NATIONAL A9-17, 20

### Two Cabins a Focus of Grief

Almost every one of the children who died at Camp Mystic was in either the Bubble Inn or Twins sites. PAGE A10

### Applying Old Rule to Beaches

The battle over how to manage sea level rise turns partly on a legal principle set down in Roman times. PAGE A9



INTERNATIONAL A4-8

### War? Yes. But the Light Is Red.

Visitors to Ukraine notice the disconnect between the front line and daily life, including the patience of pedestrians waiting to cross the street. PAGE A4

### Aftermath of Inmate Swap

More than 260 people were released from prisons in El Salvador and Venezuela. Now they face the challenge of coming home. PAGE A8

### A Major Referendum in Japan

The nation’s ruling party seemed to be heading toward a sizable defeat after Sunday’s elections, with calls for the prime minister to step down. PAGE A5

BUSINESS B1-5

### China Hawks Lose Ground

The Trump administration has dialed back aggressive measures against Beijing as the president angles for a Chinese trip later this year. PAGE B1

### No ‘Lights, Camera, Action’

The Dor Brothers production studio is fully embracing A.I. tools to generate its roster of subversive videos. PAGE B1

OBITUARIES D7-8

### A Fearless Nazi Hunter

Polina Gelman was with a female unit of Soviet aviators who attacked German troops at night. Overlooked. PAGE D8

SPORTS D1-6

### Meeting Suzuki’s Moment

Cooperstown has readied for a Japanese influx for his Hall of Fame induction. But tourism has fallen. PAGE D2

### Scheffler Reaches New Heights

Claiming the British Open, he became the fourth golfer to win that, the Masters and the P.G.A. by age 30. PAGE D3



ARTS C1-6

### Diva Takes On Directing

Renée Fleming is making her directorial debut working with young artists on Mozart’s “Così Fan Tutte.” PAGE C1

### Fresh Look at Forgotten Heist

After a de Kooning was found behind a bedroom door, a true crime fan wondered: Was more art stolen? PAGE C1

OPINION A18-19

### Amber Tamblyn

PAGE A18



SAHER ALGHORRA FOR THE NEW YORK TIMES

Mourners at Al-Shifa Hospital on Sunday after the shooting near the Zikim crossing between the northern Gaza Strip and Israel.

## How Syria’s Former Dictator Methodically Buried His Victims

This article is by *Charlie Smart, Anjali Singhvi, Bora Erden, Mika Gröndahl and K.K. Rebecca Lai.*

NAJHA, Syria — During Syria’s 13-year civil war, the Assad regime killed tens of thousands of civilians to stamp out opposition. Some of the bodies were dumped into trenches like the ones below, at the Najha cemetery.

While the existence of mass graves at Najha was previously known, a New York Times investi-

### Cemetery Transformed Into Industrial-Scale Mass Grave

gation reveals — for the first time — how the regime methodically developed the cemetery into one of the country’s largest mass gravesites.

The Times took hundreds of pho-

tographs at the site to help show the scale of burials at Najha, and analyzed satellite images, reviewed photographs and videos, and interviewed more than 20 people — including neighbors and former workers who were coerced into taking part in mass burials.

The Times’s investigation found evidence of numerous other trenches and pits at Najha that had been systematically filled with bodies over time.

Continued on Page A6

Satellite images show how mass burials at Najha cemetery progressed from excavating existing tombs to digging pits that could hold hundreds of bodies and then trenches up to 300 feet long.

Existing Tombs



Vehicles and digging

Pits



Trenches



DIEGO IBARRA SANCHEZ FOR THE NEW YORK TIMES

Falah al-Za’al overlooking the Najha burial grounds. Some of his relatives may be buried there.

## Next on the List For Mamdani: Woo His Party

By LISA LERER  
and EMMA G. FITZSIMMONS

The head of the local Democratic Party in Queens, where Assemblyman Zohran Mamdani got his political start, has never met him. The party’s longtime state chairman had not spoken to him until the day after a stunning primary night that stamped him as a rising Democratic star.

And among the party’s strategists, officials and elected leaders in Washington, he’s almost entirely unknown.

Now, as the Democratic nominee for mayor of New York City, Mr. Mamdani, 33, is on a crash course to change that. He is unleashing a full-scale charm offensive of private meetings, phone calls and public promises aimed at wooing top party leaders, donors and activists.

Last Monday, he met with Jewish elected officials in New York City. The next day, he took pointed questions about his views on Israel and tax policy from a group of 150 business leaders in the city.

A day later, he headed to Capitol Hill to offer campaign advice to dozens of Democratic members of Congress at a breakfast hosted by Representative Alexandria Oca-

Continued on Page A14

## Suspect in Minnesota Slayings Led Rambling Life of Devotion

This article is by *Dan Barry, Ernesto Londoño and Ruth Graham.*

The sudden change in the teenager was dramatic and unsettling, as if some internal switch had been thrown. Those who knew him could only wonder: What’s come over Vance Boelter?

One moment he was an affable college freshman, pursuing a family passion by trying out for the baseball team. The next, he was giving up the game and shedding his belongings — even his cherished baseball bat — as if to put away childish things.

Suddenly, he was telling dorm mates they were going to hell, denouncing a guest speaker on campus as “Satan’s worker” and announcing he was now “all in for Je-

sus.” It was a lifelong commitment he would just as suddenly violate 40 years later, prosecutors say, with an act of political assassination that would stun the nation and send his home state of Minnesota into communal mourning.

Throughout his life, Mr. Boelter’s Christian belief in the sanctity of life seemed unwavering. He told a church congregation in 2021 that all the world’s wealth was “not worth the value of the person on your left, or the person on your right, or the person you see going home today.”

But his worldview darkened as his fortunes declined. He moved from state to state, job to job. He went from overseeing large food-service operations to collecting

Continued on Page A12